



Summary Post

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The ACM *Malware Disruption* case demonstrates the significant ethical challenges that arise when service providers knowingly allow harmful cyber activity to operate on their infrastructure. Rogue Services, the hosting provider in question, advertised guaranteed uptime while enabling ransomware operations, botnets, and large-scale spam (Association for Computing Machinery, 2018). By refusing to act, Rogue violated key ACM principles, including contributing to society (1.1), avoiding harm (1.2), and respecting privacy (2.8).

A key underlying issue was the jurisdiction in which Rogue operated. Weak cybercrime legislation allowed malicious clients to act with limited accountability, illustrating how national laws often fail to address threats that easily cross borders (Brenner, 2010). When legal channels proved ineffective, investigators released a targeted worm to disrupt Rogue's malicious systems. Although intended to protect the public, this action also destroyed data without consent, raising ethical concerns about privacy, proportionality, and collateral damage issues consistent with Aiello's (2024) discussion of privacy harms.

Rogue's inaction resulted in identity theft, financial loss, and diminished trust in digital systems. These outcomes conflict not only with the ACM Code but also with the British Computer Society (BCS) Code of Conduct, which stresses safeguarding the public interest, maintaining integrity, and ensuring responsible professional behaviour (British Computer Society, 2023).

As Dignum et al. (2018) emphasize, ethical computing requires more than well-meaning intentions; it requires anticipating potential outcomes and minimizing harm through thoughtful design and responsible decision-making. Overall, the case highlights the necessity of global collaboration and consistent ethical standards to effectively address cyber threats that operate across multiple countries.

References:

Aiello, S. (2024) 'Privacy principles and harms: balancing protection and innovation', *Journal of Cybersecurity Education, Research and Practice*, 2024(1), p. 15.

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Brenner, S. (2010) *Cybercrime: Criminal Threats from Cyberspace*. Santa Barbara, CA: Praeger.

Dignum, V. et al. (2018) 'Ethics by design: necessity or curse?', in *Proceedings of the 2018 AAAI/ACM Conference on AI, Ethics, and Society*. New York: ACM, pp. 60–66.

